

UC Flare Survival Guide

This educational guide explains how ulcerative colitis flares may develop, which warning signs deserve urgent attention, and practical strategies patients often discuss with their care teams.

Understanding a Flare

- A flare occurs when inflammation becomes active again after a period of remission.
 - Symptoms can include bleeding, urgency, cramping, diarrhea, fatigue, and nighttime bowel movements.
 - Early recognition may help reduce complications and shorten flare duration.
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Emergency Warning Signs

- Heavy bleeding, severe dehydration, inability to keep fluids down, or severe abdominal pain require urgent evaluation.
 - High fever with worsening symptoms may suggest infection or severe inflammation.
 - Dizziness, fainting, or rapid heart rate may indicate significant dehydration or blood loss.
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Foods Often Better Tolerated

- Soft cooked vegetables, white rice, plain pasta, oatmeal, bananas, applesauce, broth, and lean proteins are often easier during active symptoms.
 - Small meals throughout the day may reduce cramping and digestive stress.
 - Hydration and electrolyte replacement are important during severe diarrhea.
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Foods That May Trigger Symptoms

- Spicy foods, alcohol, fried foods, excessive caffeine, and carbonated drinks may worsen symptoms in some people.
- Large meals may increase urgency and bloating during active inflammation.

- Patients may tolerate foods differently, so symptom tracking can help identify patterns.
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What Not to Do During a Flare

- Do not stop prescribed medications without guidance from your doctor.
 - Do not ignore worsening bleeding or severe dehydration symptoms.
 - Avoid excessive NSAID use such as ibuprofen or naproxen unless approved by your physician.
 - Do not wait several weeks before contacting your GI office if symptoms are escalating.
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Quick Reference Summary

Symptom	Recommended Action
Mild Increase in Symptoms	Contact GI office and monitor closely
Heavy Bleeding	Seek urgent medical evaluation
Persistent Fever	Rule out infection or severe inflammation
Severe Dehydration	Emergency care may be required

Medical Disclaimer: This educational resource is not medical advice. Always consult a licensed gastroenterologist before starting, stopping, or changing treatment.